



Container Growing Blueprint Pack

5 complete layout plans for every container type

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Container Growing Blueprint Pack

Five Printable Layout Plans for Small-Space Gardens

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A container is just a piece of ground you can move. These plans help you use every inch of it.

Important Notice

These growing plans are educational content based on real-world container gardening experience. Your results will vary depending on your climate, light exposure, container quality, and growing conditions. This is not professional agricultural advice. Use these plans as a framework and adapt based on what you observe in your own setup.

How to Use These Plans

Each plan in this pack gives you a complete picture of one container setup: what to grow in it, how to space plants, which plants work well together (and which don't), and how often to water. Print the pages for the containers you're working with and keep them with your supplies.

Before you plant any container:

- 1. Make sure it has drainage holes
- 2. Fill with quality potting mix, not garden soil
- 3. Place it in its final location before filling – containers are heavy once planted

The plans are written for standard growing season conditions in USDA Zones 5–7. Warmer zones can extend plantings; colder zones may need to shorten them.

Plan 1: Single 5-Gallon Bucket

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- SINGLE 5-GALLON BUCKET -

- Diameter: ~11" | Depth: ~12" -

- Volume: 5 gallons -

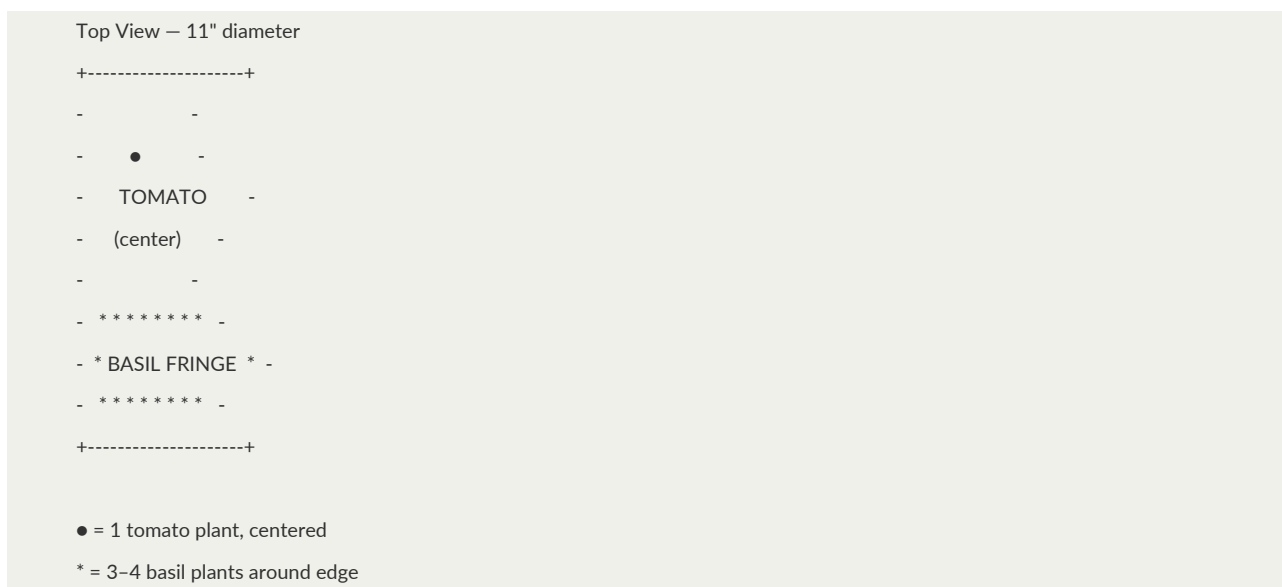
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Best Use Cases

The 5-gallon bucket is the urban grower's workhorse. Cheap, widely available, stackable, moveable. One bucket does one job — use multiples for more variety.

Planting Options (Choose One Per Bucket)

Option A: One Tomato (Cherry or Compact)



Best varieties: Tumbling Tom, Tiny Tim, Patio, Yellow Pear, Sweetie

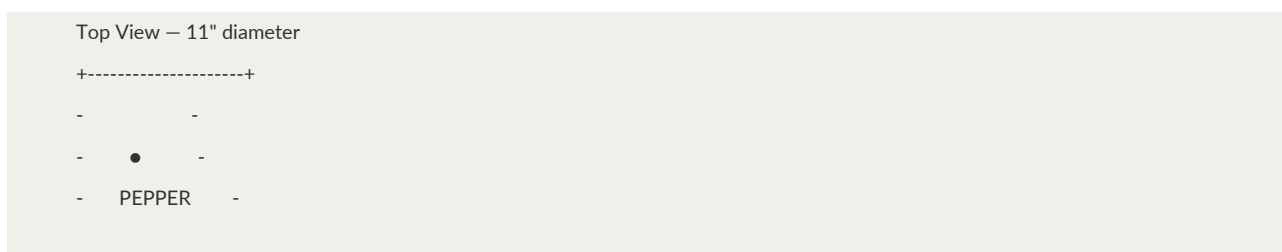
Companion planting: Basil planted at the edge of the bucket improves flavor (companion planting lore that many growers swear by), deters aphids, and gives you a bonus harvest. Plant 3–4 basil starts around the perimeter.

Spacing: Tomato centered, basil at 3–4" from the edge, spaced evenly around the circumference.

Watering: Daily in summer, especially once fruit is forming. 5-gallon buckets dry out fast in heat. A tomato plant in peak production needs close to 1–2 gallons of water per day in hot weather. Consider a self-watering insert or reservoir base.

Notes: Provide a cage or stake. Even compact cherry tomato varieties get large. A simple wire cage made from a 5-foot section of concrete reinforcing mesh is cheap and works perfectly.

Option B: One Pepper Plant



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- (center) -
- - -
- o o o o o -
- MARIGOLD RING -
+-----+

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● = 1 pepper plant
 ○ = marigolds (optional)

Best varieties: Any sweet bell, Carmen, Shishito, Banana pepper, most hot peppers (jalapeño, serrano, cayenne)

Companion planting: Marigolds around the perimeter deter aphids and spider mites. Carrots grown in a second bucket nearby are said to improve pepper growth. Avoid fennel near peppers.

Spacing: Centered, with 2–3 marigold transplants tucked around the edge if desired.

Watering: Every 1–2 days in summer. Peppers are more drought-tolerant than tomatoes but still need consistent moisture for good fruit set. Inconsistent watering causes blossom drop.

Option C: Lettuce Bucket (Cut-and-Come-Again)

Top View — 11" diameter

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- - -
- o o o o -
- - -
- o o o o -
+-----+

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○ = lettuce plants, 4" apart
 Approx. 12–16 plants per bucket

Best varieties: Any loose-leaf lettuce, salad mix, oak leaf types. Avoid large heading lettuces like iceberg.

Method: Direct sow thickly, then thin to 4" apart. Harvest outer leaves continuously, leaving the center to regrow. One bucket can provide a salad every 3–4 days for a month or more.

Watering: Every 1–2 days; more in heat. Lettuce wilts quickly when dry but recovers well when watered promptly.

Succession note: Start a second lettuce bucket 3 weeks after the first for continuous harvest.

Option D: Herb Bucket

Top View – 11" diameter

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-       -
-  o THYME  o  -
-   SAGE   -
-       -
- ROSEMARY o  -
-  o       -
-  OREGANO  -
+-----+
```

Mediterranean herb mix – good together,
similar water needs, all sun-lovers

Companion note: Group herbs by water needs. Mediterranean herbs (rosemary, thyme, oregano, sage) prefer drier conditions; basil and parsley want more moisture. Don't mix these groups in the same bucket.

Watering: Mediterranean herbs: every 3–4 days, let top inch dry between waterings. Moisture-loving herbs: every 1–2 days.

Plan 2: Window Box (24" Standard)

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+-----+
-   WINDOW BOX – 24" STANDARD   -
-   Length: 24" | Width: 6–8" | Depth: 6–8"   -
-   Volume: ~4–6 gallons         -
+-----+
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Best Use Cases

Window boxes are ideal for trailing, compact, or shallow-rooted crops — lettuces, herbs, strawberries, radishes, flowers. They're not deep enough for tomatoes or peppers.

Weight note: A filled 24" window box can weigh 20–40 lbs. Make sure your railing bracket or window ledge mount can handle the weight. When in doubt, use a lightweight potting mix with added perlite, and avoid ceramic boxes.

Layout Options

Option A: Salad Bar Box

Side View — 24" long, 6–8" deep

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- -

- o o o - o o o - o o o - o o o -

-LETTUCE 1 -LETTUCE 2 - ARUGULA - SPINACH -

+-----+

Section 1 Section 2 Section 3 Section 4

o = individual plants, 4–5" apart in rows

Each section: 3–4 plants of one variety

Why four varieties: Different textures and flavors, different maturation timing, visual interest. Plant them all at the same time and you'll harvest from one section, then move to the next as each matures.

Companion pairing: All the plants in this box are compatible. Radishes can be tucked in any gap — they mature in 25–30 days and won't compete for long.

Watering: Every 1–2 days; window boxes dry out faster than larger containers. Check daily in summer.

Option B: Herb Production Box

Side View — 24" long

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- -

- • • • - • • • - • • • -

- BASIL - PARSLEY - CILANTRO -

- (3 plants)- (2 plants)- (3 plants) -

+-----+

• = plants spaced 6–8" apart within sections

Notes: Basil, parsley, and cilantro have similar water needs (more than Mediterranean herbs). This box will need regular harvesting to prevent bolting — especially cilantro in warm weather. Succession-sow a second cilantro section every 4–6 weeks.

Watering: Every 1–2 days. Don't let this box dry out completely.

Option C: Strawberry and Nasturtium Box (Edible Flowers)

Top View — 24" long, 8" wide

+-----+

- N • N • N • N • N • N -

- NASTURTIIUM STRAWBERRY NASTURTIIUM ... -

+-----+

- = strawberry plant (6 total, 4" apart)
- N = nasturtium plant (alternating, tucked between)

Nasturtiums trail over the edge — attractive and edible.
Flowers are peppery, leaves edible in salads.

Notes: Everbearing or day-neutral strawberry varieties (like Albion or Seascape) work better in containers than June-bearing types, which produce heavily for 2–3 weeks and then very little. This box doubles as a visual feature for a balcony railing.

Watering: Every 1–2 days in summer; strawberries are relatively drought-tolerant once established.

Plan 3: Half Barrel (15-Gallon)

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- HALF BARREL / 15-GALLON CONTAINER -
- Diameter: ~18" | Depth: ~14" -
- Volume: 15 gallons -

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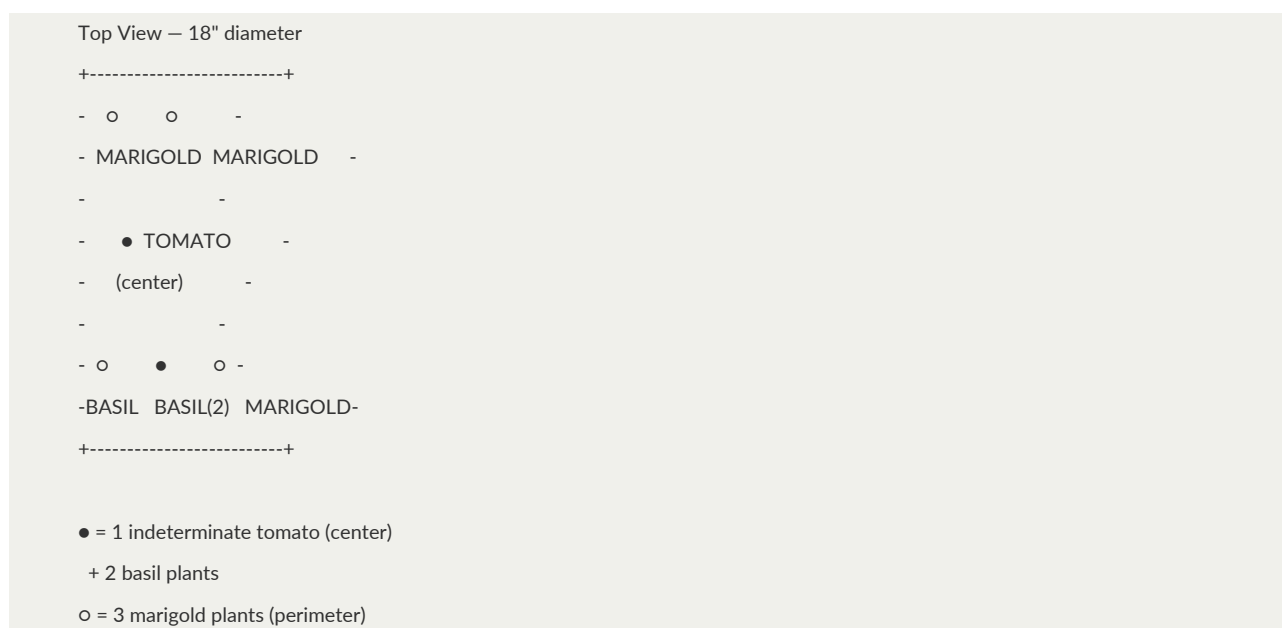
Best Use Cases

The half barrel gives you real growing depth and volume — enough for one large tomato, two or three peppers, a compact squash, or a meaningful mix of herbs and companions. This is where you can start doing interesting multi-plant combinations.

Weight note: A filled half barrel can weigh 80–120 lbs. Position it before filling. Consider placing it on a dolly with wheels for any future repositioning needs.

Layout Options

Option A: Tomato Centerpiece



Best tomato varieties for this size: Cherokee Purple, Black Krim, Brandywine (all will need staking), or any large cherry/cocktail tomato.

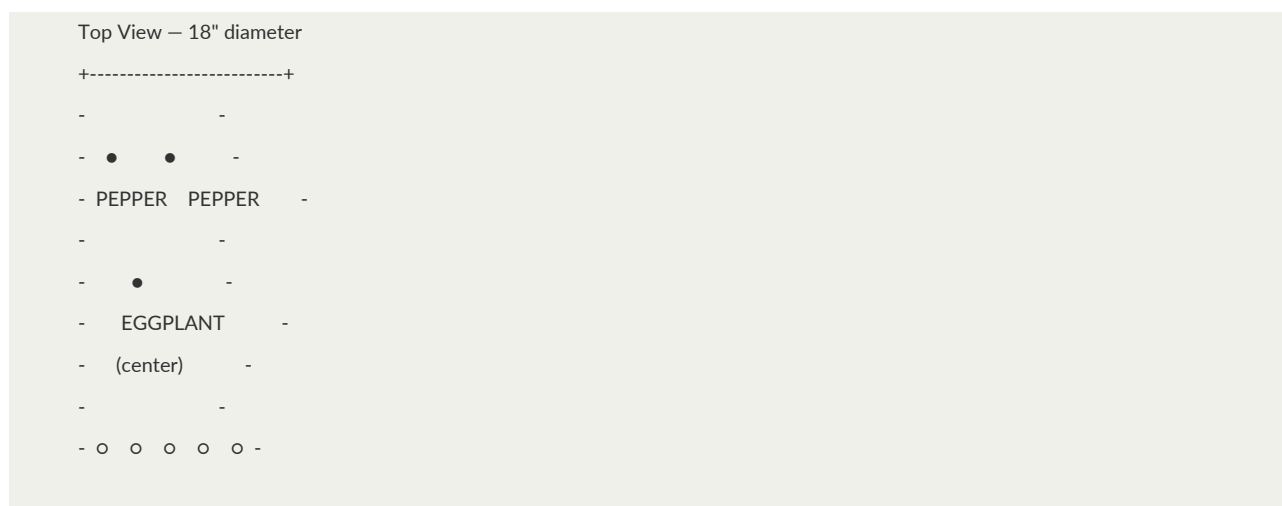
Spacing: Tomato centered, basil 6–8" to either side of tomato, marigolds filling the remaining perimeter.

Companion rationale: Basil is the classic tomato companion — anecdotally improves flavor, definitely improves the cook. Marigolds deter nematodes and aphids. Both are true companions, not just decoration.

Watering: Every day in summer, possibly twice a day during heat waves. A 15-gallon container with a large tomato plant in July needs 2–3 gallons of water per day. A self-watering reservoir insert is worth the investment for this setup.

Notes: Provide a 6-foot stake or large cage. Use two stakes if the plant grows particularly large. Top-dress with compost or worm castings monthly to maintain fertility through the season.

Option B: Pepper and Eggplant Trio



- Watering: Every 1-2 days. These crops are more drought-tolerant than tomatoes but consistent moisture is key to preventing blossom drop.

$$+ \text{-----} +$$

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- O O -

- THYME OREGANO -

—

- ● LAVENDER -

- (center/feature) -

—

- o CHIVES o THYME (2) -

+

Watering: Every 3–5 days; allow top 2 inches to dry between waterings.

- 2x4 RAISED BED -

- Length: 4' | Width: 2' | Depth: 10-12" -

- Volume: ~30-40 gallons

Best Use Cases

The 2x4 raised bed is the gateway to serious small-space growing. At 8 square feet, you have enough room for genuine crop diversity. The 2-foot width means you can reach the center from either side without stepping in. This plan uses a modified version of Square Foot Gardening spacing.

Layout

Option A: Balanced Seasonal Bed (Spring/Fall)

Top View — 4' long x 2' wide

Each cell = 6" x 6"

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+---+---+---+---+---+---+---+
- L - L - R - R - R - R - S - S - ROW 1
+---+---+---+---+---+---+---+
- L - L - R - R - R - R - S - S - ROW 2
+---+---+---+---+---+---+---+
- K - K - K - K - P - P - P - C - ROW 3
+---+---+---+---+---+---+---+
- K - K - K - K - P - P - P - C - ROW 4
+---+---+---+---+---+---+---+

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L = Lettuce (8 plants, 6" spacing)

R = Radishes (16 plants, 3" spacing — 4 per 6" cell)

S = Spinach (8 plants, 6" spacing)

K = Kale (8 plants, 6" spacing — thin to 12" as they mature)

P = Parsley/cilantro (6 plants, 6" spacing)

C = Chives (1 clump per cell)

Total plants: ~47 plants across 6 varieties. This bed will need thinning as plants mature. Succession sow radishes into harvested spaces every 3 weeks.

Option B: Summer Bed (After Last Frost)

Top View — 4' long x 2' wide

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+-----+-----+
-       -       -
-  TOMATO (1)  - PEPPERS (2)  -
- (full 2'x2'  - one on each side  -
- corner)    - of center      -
-       -       -
+-----+-----+
- BASIL - BASIL - MARIGOLDS (border) -

```

+-----+-----+ -

- BEAN BEAN BEAN- BEAN BEAN BEAN -

- (back row, - (front row, bush) -

- bush variety) - -

+-----+-----+-----+

- Tomato: 1 indeterminate, northwest corner (won't shade rest)
- Peppers: 2 plants, 18" apart, center-east section
- Basil: 4 plants in front of tomato
- Beans: 6 plants in front row, 4" apart (bush variety)
- Marigolds: perimeter border east side

Notes: Place the tomato at the north end (or the end away from the sun) so it doesn't shade other crops. The beans in the front row will finish before the tomatoes reach full height.

Watering: This summer bed needs daily watering in peak heat. Drip irrigation or a soaker hose at the base of plants is worth setting up — it reduces disease (no wet foliage) and saves time.

- Companion pairings:
- Tomato + basil: classic, practical, beneficial
 - Beans + marigolds: marigolds deter bean beetles
 - Peppers + basil: peppers benefit from basil proximity

Avoid planting together: fennel (allelopathic — inhibits many vegetables), brassicas near tomatoes.

Plan 5: Grow Bag Cluster — Five 3-Gallon Bags

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- GROW BAG CLUSTER -

- Five 3-gallon fabric grow bags -

- Each: ~10" diameter, ~10" deep -

- Total footprint: ~24" x 24" clustered -

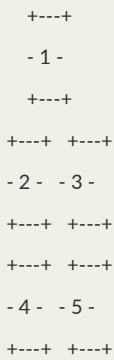
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Why Grow Bags?

Fabric grow bags air-prune roots — when roots reach the air at the bag's edge, they stop growing outward and branch inward instead, creating a denser, more efficient root system. This means you get better growth from smaller containers compared to plastic pots of the same size. They're also lightweight, cheap, and pack flat when not in use.

Cluster Layout

Overhead View — Five bags arranged in tight cluster



Total footprint: approximately 24" x 30"
Can fit on a 2' x 3' section of balcony or patio

Planting Options

Option A: Five-Herb Kitchen Garden

Bag	Plant	Notes
1 (center/top)	Basil	Needs most water; center is easiest to w
2	Parsley	Biennial; will survive light frost
3	Cilantro	Succession-sow every 4 weeks; this is yo
4	Thyme	Drought-tolerant; don't overwater
5	Chives	Perennial; comes back each year; largely

Companion note: These five herbs don't directly compete but have different water needs. Water bags 1, 2, and 3 more frequently; bags 4 and 5 less often. The cluster makes this easy — just pay attention to which bags feel light (dry).

Watering: Bags 1–3 every 1–2 days in summer. Bags 4–5 every 2–3 days.

Option B: Five-Pepper Collection

Bag	Plant	Variety (suggestions)
1	Sweet pepper	Carmen, Lipstick, Corno di Toro
2	Mild hot	Poblano, Anaheim, Hatch
3	Medium hot	Jalapeño, Serrano
4	Hot	Cayenne, Thai hot
5	Specialty	Shishito, Padron, Aji Amarillo

Why this works: Peppers are perfectly sized for 3-gallon bags. Five bags in a cluster can hold a serious pepper collection in 6 square feet. Peppers are also wind-tolerant compared to tomatoes, which makes this cluster a good fit for an exposed balcony.

Companion note: Plant a small pot of basil between or near the cluster. Marigolds in a window box nearby add pest deterrence.

Watering: Every 1–2 days; pepper bags dry out fast in hot weather.

Option C: Salad and Snack Garden

Bag	Plant	Notes
1	Cherry tomato (compact)	Tumbling Tom or Tiny Tim
2	Lettuce mix	Scatter-seeded, cut-and-come-again
3	Radishes	Direct-sow, 25-day turnaround, successio
4	Bush beans	4–5 plants per bag
5	Basil + marigolds	Companion bag — benefits everything arou

This cluster gives you something to harvest from every 2–3 days through the summer. The tomato provides the centerpiece; the lettuce and radishes keep it interesting in early season; the beans add substance mid-summer.

Watering: Tomato bag needs daily watering in summer. Lettuce and beans every 1–2 days. Radishes every 1–2 days. Basil/marigold bag every 1–2 days.

General Grow Bag Notes

Watering frequency: Fabric grow bags dry out 20–30% faster than plastic containers of the same size because moisture evaporates through the sides. In peak summer, daily watering is normal. You can slow this down by placing bags on a tray with a small amount of water, or by clustering them tightly (the bags shade each other's sides, reducing evaporation).

Fertilizing: Because of frequent watering, nutrients wash out of grow bags faster than any other container type. Feed every 10–14 days with a balanced liquid fertilizer throughout the growing season.

Winter storage: Empty, wash, and fold flat. They store in almost no space and last 3–5 seasons with reasonable care.

Quick Reference: Companion Planting Summary

Plant	Good Neighbors	Poor Neighbors
Tomatoes	Basil, parsley, marigolds, carrots	Fennel, brassicas
Peppers	Basil, marigolds, carrots	Fennel
Lettuce	Radishes, carrots, chives	None significant
Beans	Marigolds, nasturtiums, summer savory	Onions, fennel
Basil	Tomatoes, peppers	Sage
Marigolds	Everything	Nothing
Cucumbers	Beans, dill, marigolds	Sage, rosemary
Kale	Beets, celery, herbs	Tomatoes, strawberries

Watering Quick Guide

Container	Daily in Summer	Every 2 Days	Every 3+ Days
3-gal grow bag	Tomatoes, basil	Peppers, lettuce	Mediterranean herbs
5-gal bucket	Tomatoes	Peppers, lettuce	Mediterranean herbs
Window box	Basil, lettuce	Herbs	Strawberries (established)
Half barrel	Tomatoes	Peppers	Herb garden
2x4 raised bed	Summer crops (peak heat)	Spring/fall crops	N/A

These are guidelines. The real answer is always: stick your finger 1–2 inches into the soil. If it's dry, water. If it's moist, wait.

These plans are starting points. Every balcony gets different sun, every apartment has different temperatures, and every grower learns different things about their specific containers over time. Pay attention to what your plants are telling you — they'll adjust your plans for you.

— Seedwarden

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